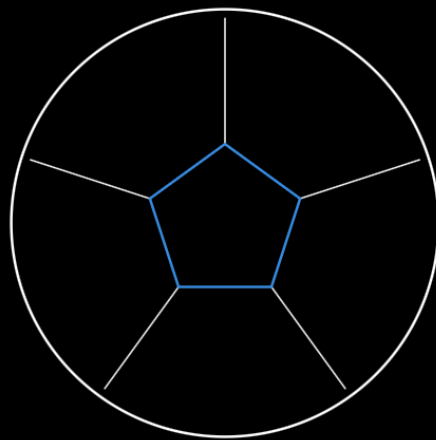


YOUTH SOCCER GUIDES

COLLEGE

How To Actually Get Recruited



PAUL SPACEY

COLLEGE SOCCER RECRUITMENT

Paul Spacey

Here's what nobody tells you about college soccer recruitment: coaches aren't looking for your kid. Your kid has to find them.

Most high school soccer players will not be "discovered." There is no scout in the stands writing down your child's name. The players who get recruited are the ones whose parents understood the process and executed it early.

The college recruitment landscape changed dramatically in 2025. The House v. NCAA settlement rewrote the rules. More scholarship money is available than ever before. But more players are chasing it, and the window to act is shorter than you think.

This guide gives you the exact steps in order. No theory. No fluff. Just what works. If your child is already a junior or senior, compress the timeline but maintain the sequence.

Note: College recruiting rules change fast. Always verify the latest NCAA guidelines at eligibilitycenter.org.

THE NEW RULES

⊗ **WHAT CHANGED IN 2025 (AND WHY IT MATTERS)**

The House v. NCAA settlement effective July 2025 fundamentally changed college soccer recruiting. If you're operating on old information, you're already behind.

What changed:

- D1 men's soccer scholarships jumped from 9.9 to up to 28. That sounds like good news. It is and it isn't. More scholarship money means more players accepting partial offers instead of walking on. Walk-on spots are shrinking fast.
- All sports can now split scholarships into partial awards. A coach who used to offer 9 full rides now spreads that money across 20+ players. Smaller offers, more competition for each one.
- The National Letter of Intent is gone. Players and schools are no longer locked in the same way. This means more movement, more uncertainty, and more importance on building real relationships with coaches rather than relying on a binding document.
- Revenue sharing is now permitted. Schools with money will use it to attract top talent. The gap between well-funded and underfunded programs is about to get wider.

What this means for your family:

- Start earlier. The players getting offers are the ones coaches have been watching since sophomore year. Waiting until senior year is too late for most programs.
- Cast a wider net. With more partial scholarships available, your child has more options but needs to contact more schools to find the right financial and athletic fit.
- Don't chase prestige. A partial scholarship at a D2 program that develops players might be worth more than walking on at a D1 school where your kid sits on the bench for four years.

⊗ **NIL (NAME, IMAGE, LIKENESS)**

Since 2021, college athletes can earn money from their name, image, and likeness. After the 2025 settlement, this accelerated. Top recruits now factor NIL deals into their decisions alongside scholarships and playing time.

Most high school players won't land big NIL money. But even small local sponsorships and social media presence matter. Coaches and NIL collectives look at both athletic ability and marketability.

Start building your child's highlight video presence and social media now. Not for vanity. Because it's part of the recruiting equation whether you like it or not.

STEP 1 / 6

BUILD YOUR TARGET LIST

Do this: Sophomore year at the latest.

Most families start with "I want my kid to play D1." Wrong starting point. Start with fit.

Three categories. Build a list of at least 20 schools across three tiers:

- Reach schools (4-5): Programs where your child would need significant improvement or a standout showcase performance to get noticed.
- Target schools (10-12): Programs that match your child's current ability level. This is where most offers come from.
- Safety schools (4-5): Programs where your child would be a strong addition. These are not lesser schools. They're realistic options.

For each school, answer: Can my kid play there? Can we afford it? Does the academic program fit? Is the location realistic?

Use the NCAA Eligibility Center (eligibilitycenter.org) to confirm your child meets academic requirements. Do this now, not when a coach asks.

STEP 2 / 6

MAKE THE HIGHLIGHT VIDEO

This is your child's resume. Most highlight videos are terrible. Here's why yours won't be.

- Keep it 3-5 minutes. Coaches watch hundreds. They won't finish a 10-minute video. They might not finish a 5-minute one.
- Lead with the best 3 plays. First 30 seconds determine whether a coach keeps watching.
- Game footage only. Training clips mean nothing. Coaches want to see decision-making under pressure, not juggling in the backyard.
- Show position-specific skills. A midfielder should show distribution and positioning. A striker should show movement and finishing. A defender should show 1v1 defending and composure on the ball.
- Include your jersey number in the title card. Name, graduation year, position, club team, high school, GPA, contact info. Make it easy.
- Upload to YouTube. Public or unlisted. Test the link before you send it to anyone. Update it every 3-4 months with new footage.

STEP 3 / 6**⊗ MAKE CONTACT**

Email is the primary tool. Not Instagram DMs. Not showing up at the coach's office. Email.

Subject line example: Striker – ECNL Level – 3.5 GPA – High Budget – Available Fall 2027

Adapt to your child's details. Position, level, GPA, budget range, availability. Coaches scan hundreds of subject lines. Make yours impossible to skip.

High Budget tells the coach your family can cover most tuition. Use Mid Budget or Need Aid if that's more accurate. Coaches appreciate honesty here. It saves everyone time.

Sample outreach email:

Dear Coach [Last Name],

My name is [Player Name], a [position] from [City, State]. I play for [Club Name] and attend [High School] with a [X.XX] GPA. I graduate in [year].

I'm reaching out because your program's emphasis on player development and strong academic support fits what I'm looking for. Here's my highlight video: [YouTube link]

I'll be at [upcoming tournament/showcase] on [dates] if you're able to attend. I'd welcome the chance to learn more about your program.

[Player Name]
[Phone] | [Email]

That's it. Short, specific, professional. Send it.

- Send 10-15 emails per week. Expect a 10-20% response rate. That's normal. Four responses out of 40 emails is a win if one of them leads somewhere.

- Follow up two weeks later. Brief. Updated video link if you have new footage. Mention any upcoming tournaments or showcases where the coach could see you play.
- If a coach responds, reply within 24 hours. Every time. Speed signals genuine interest.

STEP 4 / 6

⊗ **ATTEND ID CAMPS AND
SHOWCASES**

ID camps run by college coaching staffs are the single best way to get evaluated. Period.

- Prioritize camps at your target schools. This puts you directly in front of the coach who makes recruiting decisions. No middleman.
- Email the coach before the camp. Tell them you're attending and you're interested in their program. Email them after the camp. Thank them and reference something specific from the experience.
- Showcases (multi-team tournaments with college scouts) are your second priority. They're efficient because multiple coaches see you in one weekend. But they're also crowded. You're one of hundreds.
- Register for 2-3 ID camps and 1-2 showcases per year starting sophomore year.
- Cost adds up. Budget \$200-500 per camp, plus travel. This is an investment. Treat it like one.

STEP 5 / 6

⊗ **UNDERSTAND THE MONEY**

This is where most families get blindsided.

- D1: Up to 28 scholarships for men's soccer now. Sounds generous. But offer sizes vary wildly by program. Some spread money thin across the full roster. Others concentrate it on key recruits. Ask specifically what your child's offer would look like.
- D2: Partial scholarships available. Often combined with academic aid to create a meaningful package. Don't overlook D2.
- D3: Zero athletic scholarships. But strong academic and merit aid can make D3 schools surprisingly affordable. And the soccer-to-academics balance is often better.
- NAIA: Scholarships available and sometimes more generous than D2. Smaller schools, but real opportunities.

Ask the coach directly: "What does a typical financial aid package look like for a player in my position?" Coaches expect this question. Don't be afraid of it.

Run the net price calculator on every school's website. The sticker price is not the real price.

⊗ **RED FLAGS (WALK AWAY FROM THESE)**

- A coach who promises specific playing time. They can't guarantee it. If they do, they're selling you.
- A coach who won't put a scholarship offer in writing. Verbal offers mean nothing.
- A coach who pressures you to commit immediately. Legitimate programs give you time to decide.
- A coach who discourages you from contacting current players. What are they hiding?
- High coaching staff turnover. The coach who recruited your child might not be there sophomore year. Research staff stability.
- A program on NCAA probation or sanctions. This limits scholarships and postseason play. Check before you commit.

STEP 6 / 6

PARENT BEHAVIORS

Your job is logistics, support, and staying out of the way. In that order.

- Do the research. Build the target list. Handle camp registrations and travel. Your child should focus on playing.
- Do not email coaches on your child's behalf. Coaches want to hear from the player. A parent who does all the communicating is a red flag.
- Do not call coaches to argue about playing time, selection, or scholarship amounts. This will end your child's recruitment at that school. Guaranteed.
- Do attend games, showcases, and campus visits. Be present but invisible. Coaches are watching you too.
- After a campus visit, let your child lead the conversation. Ask "What did you think?" before offering your opinion.

⊗ **RECRUITMENT TIMELINE**

Freshman year: Focus on development. Register with the NCAA Eligibility Center. Start researching schools casually. Sophomore year: Build target list. Create highlight video. Send first wave of emails. Attend 1-2 ID camps. Junior year: This is the critical year. Heavy email outreach. 2-3 ID camps, 1-2 showcases. Campus visits to top choices. Junior year is when most serious conversations happen. Commitments can come anytime from junior year through senior year. Senior year: Finalize decisions. Official visits. Sign financial aid agreements. If you haven't started the process by senior year, your options are limited but not zero. Compress the timeline and execute every step.

⚽ **WHAT TO DO RIGHT NOW**

This month:

- Register at eligibilitycenter.org if you haven't
- Build a list of 15 schools across all three tiers
- Film or compile highlight footage from recent games
- Draft your first outreach email

Next 3 months:

- Send emails to your first 20 target schools
- Register for 1-2 ID camps this summer
- Update your highlight video
- Run net price calculators on your top 10 schools

This year:

- Expand your list to 25-30 schools
- Attend 2-3 camps and 1-2 showcases
- Follow up persistently with every coach who responds
- Schedule campus visits to your top 5

The players who get recruited aren't always the most talented. They're the most prepared. Start now.

⊗ **Get the Full System**

Free got you started. These four go all the way.

Youth Soccer Tryouts: \$39

Everything coaches look for, and what parents get wrong.

10-Step Plan: \$39

The full development roadmap. How to build a top 1% player by age 10.

Youth Soccer Parents: \$39

How to help your child without getting in the way.

The Complete Bundle: \$87

All three guides in one. Everything you need, best value.